The Day I Swapped My Dad for Two Goldfish

By Neil Gaiman

BOY: One day my mom went out and left me at home with just my little sister and my dad. My dad sat in front of the television, reading his newspaper. My dad doesn't pay much attention to anything, when he's reading his newspaper. My little sister and I played in the garden. My sister played with her Barbie dolls, and I played at putting mud down my sister's neck. My friend Nathan came over to my house. He had a glass bowl with him. There was something in the glass bowl. *(to Nathan)* "What's that?"

NATHAN: Two goldfish. They are called Sawney and Beaney. Aren't they neat?

BOY: They were pretty neat. *(to Nathan)* I'll swap you them.

NATHAN: What for?

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INTRODUCTION

When a boy swaps his dad for two goldfish, he doesn't really think about the consequences . . .

BOY: *Did so!*

After all, who would have suspected that ***other*** *kids would go around swapping stuff too.*

BOY: *Okay . . . maybe I didn't think about that!*

And when his ***mom*** *finds out . . .*

BOY: *Who knew he'd be* ***that*** *valuable anyway??*

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BOY: We went up to my bedroom. My little sister tagged along. I showed Nathan my old transformer robots and my baseball cards and my books. I showed him my old punching bag and my penny whistle that Mommy said made her head ache when I blew it. I showed him my old spaceship that didn't float in the bath anymore, and the puppet with the tangled strings, and I even shoed him Clownie, my clown that I sleep with. And every time I showed him something, Nathan said, "No." We went downstairs. *(to Nathan)* Isn't there anything you would swap for the goldfish? *(to audience)* They were very nice goldfish. They were reddy-gold, and they swam backwards and forwards in their bowl.

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NATHAN: No, not transformer robots or baseball cards or books or a punching bag., or a penny whistle, even if it does make your mom's head ache, or a spaceship or a puppet or even that old Clownie.

BOY: I thought for a bit. Some people have great ideas maybe once or twice in their life, and then they discover electricity or fire or outer space or something. I mean, the kind of brilliant ideas that change the whole world. Some people never have them at all. I get them two or three times a week. *(to Nathan)* I'll swap you my dad.

SISTER: Oh-oh!

NATHAN: That's not a fair swap. I've got two goldfish and you've only got one dad.

BOY: He's bigger than your goldfish, though. He's as big as a hundred goldfish.

NATHAN: Can he swim?

BOY: Better than a goldfish.

SISTER: Liar. He splashes and splashes at the swimming pool.

NATHAN: Okay.

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BOY: He gave me the two goldfish in the goldfish bowl, and took my dad away with him. I watched the goldfish for a while.

SISTER: You'll get into big trouble when Mommy gets home. You'll see.

BOY: When my mother came home I said . . . Mom, can we buy some gold fish food?

MOTHER: If we have to, dear. Where's your father?

BOY: *(to mother)* Come and see my goldfish. Aren't they pretty? *(to audience)* She shouted up the stairs. She knocked on the door of the bathroom. She called out into the garden. My father didn't reply.

SISTER: Mumf, mumf, mumf!

BOY: *(to mother)* Don't pay any attention to her. Come and look at my goldfish. *(to audience)* But my mother untied my little sister and took the sock out of her mouth.

MOTHER: Do you know where your father is?

SISTER: *(pointing at the speaker)* He swapped him to his friend Nathan for those two goldfish.

MOTHER: *(sharply)* Young man, is this true?

BOY: *(to audience)* She only calls me young man if she's very, very mad. *(to mother)* Yes.

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MOTHER: Right. *(picking up the bowl of goldfish and handing it to speaker)* You can take these goldfish over to Nathan this minute, and don't you come back without your father.

SISTER: I told you so!

MOTHER: And you can go with him. Fancy allowing your brother to swap your father for two goldfish and a bowl. The very idea.

BOY: So we went to Nathan's house. He only lives over the road. I knocked on the door. Nathan's mother came out. *(to Nathan's mother)* Is Nathan here?

N's MOM: Where did you get those goldfish?They were a present to Nathan from his Aunt Violet.

BOY: I swapped them. And now I have to swap them back again. *(to audience)* She sent Nathan out to talk to me. *(to Nathan)* Here are your gold fish. Now can I have my dad back, please?

NATHAN: Well, yes and no.

SISTER: Oh-oh!

BOY: We went upstairs to Nathan's bedroom. It was even messier than my bedroom. Nathan had an electric guitar, a big white one.

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NATHAN: I swapped this electric guitar with Vashti Singh.

BOY: Nathan, what did you swap to Vashti, so she would give you her electric guitar?"

NATHAN: If you get off me, I will tell you . . . I swapped her your dad. Well, he wasn't very exciting. All he did was read the paper.

BOY: I took the guitar and we walked over to Vashti's house. *(to sister)* I could be a rock and roll star!

SISTER: You could be an idiot.

BOY: I rang Vashti's doorbell. *(to Vashti)* I've got your guitar for you. *(to audience)* Vashti giggled. All Vashti's sisters giggled too. *(to Vashti)* Can I have my dad back, please? *(to audience)* They giggled again.

VASHTI: *(shrugging her shoulders)* Wait here.

BOY: She took the guitar away from me. When she came back she was carrying a gorilla mask. *(to Vashti)* Oh, no.

VASHTI: I swapped your dad with Blinky. Blinky had this really good gorilla mask "

BOY: Where's Blinky's house?" *(to audience)* She told me how to get there. It was going to be a long walk. We set off.

SISTER: Can I put on the gorilla mask?

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BOY: She put on the gorilla mask. *(to sister - laughing)* When are you going to put it on? When are you going to put on the gorilla mask? *(to audience)* My little sister took off the gorilla mask. We walked some more. I put on the gorilla mask. My sister went over to a policeman.

SISTER: Help! Quick! That gorilla is escaping from the zoo!

BOY: The policeman ran over and caught me. He made me take off the mask. Then he told me off. He would have told my sister off, only she did her innocent little girl face so he didn't. It's not fair. *(sister giggles) (to sister)* Watch it. Just watch it that's all. *(to audience)* Blinky had a very big house. We went up to the front and rang the bell. The butler came out. *(to butler)* Can we speak to Blinky? *(to audience)* Blinky came down the big stairs. He looked very pleased to see the gorilla mask.

BLINKY: Are you bringing it back?

BOY: Yes, we are. *(to audience)* Blinky made the butler give us ginger beer. I liked it even though the bubbles tickled my nose. My sister made a face. *(to Blinky after drinking the ginger beer)* Now, where's my dad? *(to audience)* He went away again around the side of the house.

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BLINKY: *(returning)* This is Galveston.

BOY: Galveston was a fat white rabbit with one black ear.

BLINKY: Galveston's what I swapped your father for.

BOY: I gave him the gorilla mask. He gave me Galveston and a map he drew of how to get to Patti's house. I'd never walked so far in my whole life.

SISTER: I think ginger beer is the most horrible thing in the whole world.

BOY: Worse than boiled beets?

SISTER: No, not that bad.

BOY: While we walked, Galveston the Rabbit sat in my arms and made its nose go woffly. My sister tried to make her nose go as woffly as Galveston's, but she couldn't do it. I knocked on the door of Patti's house.

PATTI: Galveston!

BOY: [She] took the rabbit away from us and fussed over it and gave it some lettuce, [then she] took my hand. We walked into the back garden. There was a little rabbit hutch there and next to the rabbit hutch was a little run with chicken wire all around it. My dad sat on the grass,

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in the chicken wire run reading his newspaper and eating a carrot. He looked a bit lonely, and he had grass all over his trousers. *(to Dad – opening the gate)* Come on, Dad. *(to audience)* My dad crawled through the gate on his hands and knees.

PATTI: He's not a very good rabbit.

BOY: He's not meant to be. He's a very good daddy.

PATTI: He can keep the carrot. Thanks for bringing back Galveston.

BOY: No problem. Seeya.

SISTER: You like her. I can tell. I'm going to tell everyone at school.

BOY: Last week my little sister told everyone at school that I was adopted. The week before she told everyone at school that I was a space alien pretending to be me.

SISTER: If you do, I'll tell everyone that you're secretly fat.

DAD: Children.

BOY: And he carried on eating his carrot and reading his paper until we go home. When we got home my mother said things like, "Just look at the state of him!" and she made him go and have a bath and she put all his clothes into the washing. While Dad was in the

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bath, my mother told me off. And when she'd finished telling me off, she made me promise, cross my heart, that I would never – ever – swap my dad for anything ever, ever again. And I promised. So I won't. But I never promised anything about my little sister . . . . .

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